

Distance Learning and Remote Education Policy

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This policy provides a framework for the design, delivery and quality assurance of distance learning and remote education. It aims to expand access to higher education while maintaining academic standards, ensuring fair assessment and supporting learners who study outside the traditional campus setting.

1. Background

Higher education systems face a tension between growing demand and limited campus capacity. Distance learning offers a path to widen access, but it must be accompanied by strong academic design, credible assessment and support for students who may be dispersed geographically or in employment. This policy is informed by the experience of rapid remote teaching and by international best practice in distance education.

2. Purpose

The purpose of this policy is to set clear expectations for institutions designing and delivering distance learning programmes. It defines standards for academic design, student support, assessment and programme governance, while leaving institutions flexibility to innovate in how these standards are met.

3. Objectives

- Increase access to higher education through quality distance and remote learning programmes.
- Establish consistent academic standards across distance, blended and on-campus programmes.
- Ensure learner support is tailored to the needs of distance students.
- Provide credible, secure and fair assessment in distance settings.
- Enable credit transfer and progression for distance learners.
- Guide institutions in the use of appropriate learning technologies.

4. Scope

This policy applies to all universities and affiliated institutions offering degrees, diplomas or certificates wholly or substantially through distance or remote learning. It does not apply to emergency remote teaching arrangements, which are governed by separate, time-limited instructions.

5. Definitions

- Distance learning: a mode where learner and institution are separated by location, time or both, and where interaction is mediated by technology.
- Remote education: instruction delivered via digital platforms, which may include scheduled online sessions, asynchronous modules and online assessment.
- Blended learning: a mix of in-person and online learning, which is subject to the Digital Learning Policy where the in-campus element is dominant.

6. Academic Design and Approval

Institutions offering distance learning must ensure the following before seeking approval of a new programme: (i) a clear programme structure with defined learning outcomes and credit value; (ii) a detailed syllabus indicating online and offline components; (iii) an assessment strategy that ensures integrity; and (iv) a student support plan addressing counselling, library access and technical help.

7. Student Support

Distance learners are entitled to: a dedicated helpdesk; access to a library service sufficient for the programme's needs; academic counselling; technology support; timely feedback on assessments; and a student representation system. The institution must communicate these services clearly at enrolment and throughout the programme.

8. Assessment

Assessment must combine regular low-stakes tasks with a final assessment that is secure and conducted under appropriate conditions. Techniques may include proctored online tests, assignment submission, portfolio assessment and project work. Clear guidance on academic integrity must be provided to students and enforced.

9. Quality Assurance

Distance programmes are subject to the same institutional quality assurance processes as other programmes. Additional quality indicators include completion rates, time to completion, assessment integrity records, student support utilisation and graduate employment or progression outcomes. External review of distance programmes should include appropriate expertise in distance education.

10. Credit Transfer

Credits earned through a recognised distance programme are transferable subject to the Credit Transfer Guidelines issued under this policy. Institutions must establish and publish a clear credit transfer process that ensures fairness and transparency.

11. Technology and Digital Inclusion

Institutions must select technology that is reliable, accessible and appropriate to their learner population. Where technology costs present a barrier to participation, institutions must explore measures to support access, including offline materials, low-bandwidth options or device lending. The Learning Management System must support standard features for content delivery, assessment and communication.

12. Governance and Data

Institutions must designate a lead for distance learning with responsibility for quality, student experience and compliance. Student data must be handled in accordance with data protection norms. The Higher Education Department will receive annual reports on participation, completion, complaints and external review outcomes.

13. Enforcement and Consequences

Non-compliance with this policy may result in remedial action plans, conditions on new programme approvals, suspension of admissions or, in serious cases, withdrawal of recognition for the programme. Institutions may seek guidance from the department before problems escalate.

14. Review

This policy will be reviewed at least every three years. It will be updated to reflect changes in technology, learner needs and national qualification frameworks. The department will consult institutions, students and industry stakeholders in each review.

15. Contact

Questions about this policy should be directed to the Higher Education Department's academic planning and quality division, accessible through the HEIRS portal.